

Is a Journalism Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The complete profile — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest downsides, and what to ask before you commit.

8.3

AI EXPOSURE · DESK / AGGREGATION & REWRITE

where 10 is most at risk

Read this one first; send the student version to them.



Before you read this — a note for parents

You're likely reading this before your child is. That's normal, and it's worth pausing on how you use it.

Don't lead with the scores. And in this profile, don't lead with the industry data either.

This is the hardest document in the index, and we've thought carefully about how to write it. The honest picture for journalism is worse than for any other career we score — and crucially, **most of what makes it hard has nothing to do with AI.** The industry has been contracting for twenty-five years for economic reasons, and our framework can't see any of it.

What this is. A facts document, not a recommendation. We have not softened the numbers, because a document that did would be doing real harm to someone about to spend three years and a lot of money.

But we've also not written it as a case against journalism, because the skills are genuinely valuable, the work matters, and there are places that are hiring. The honest advice is narrow rather than negative.

One request. If your child wants to do this, they almost certainly know some of what follows. The useful thing you can offer is not the bad news — they've heard it. It's helping them work out which specific version of this career still exists, and how to get there.

The short answer

Not as a route to a newsroom desk job — that path is close to closed, and mostly for reasons that predate AI by two decades.

Desk journalism — aggregation, rewriting, routine news production — scores **8.3** out of 10. Investigative reporting scores **5.1**.

But **journalism is the profession where our score is least useful on its own**, and we'd rather say that plainly than let a number do work it hasn't earned. The industry's problem is economic. AI is the accelerant, not the cause.

The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Investigative reporting	4.5	4.8	5.1	+0.6	Moderate
Specialist / trade reporting	5.2	5.5	5.8	+0.6	Moderate
Data journalism	5.7	6.1	6.5	+0.8	Moderate-High
General news reporting	6.0	6.4	6.7	+0.7	Moderate-High
Desk / aggregation & rewrite	7.0	7.8	8.3	+1.3	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, graphic design production scores 8.4, and entry-level software development 8.1.

Note where this starts. Desk journalism was already at 7.0 in 2023 — the highest 2023 score of any track in this index. Its problem substantially predates the current wave, and the score reflects a profession that had already been squeezed for two decades.

Read the score carefully — this is the important section

We'd normally save the market context for later. In journalism it belongs before anything else, because the number on its own is misleading.

Our index measures automation exposure. It does not measure industry health. In most professions those track together closely enough that the distinction is academic. In journalism they have come apart completely.

The scale of what happened, and none of it was AI:

- Employment in American publishing has fallen roughly **40% since the late 1990s** — from around 91,000 jobs to about 55,000
- BLS figures put reporters, correspondents and broadcast news analysts at roughly 45,000–50,000 today, down from a peak near 114,000 in 2008 — close to a 60% decline
- Pew Research found newsroom employment at newspapers fell **by more than half between 2008 and 2020**
- Around **2,900 newspapers have closed** in the US since 2005, leaving over 200 counties with no local news outlet at all

- BLS projects editor roles growing about **1% annually** — a rounding error from an industry-wide hiring freeze

What caused it: classified revenue moving to the platforms, advertising moving to search and social, and audiences fragmenting. That process ran its course before generative AI existed.

So what is AI actually doing here? It is removing the shock absorber. Desk work — rewriting wire copy, aggregating other outlets, producing routine reports — was the role that survived earlier rounds precisely because someone had to do it. That is the part now automating, which takes the remaining cushion out of an industry that had already used up its slack.

And there's a quality dimension worth naming. AI adoption is heaviest in exactly the places least equipped to check it — resource-strapped local newsrooms experimenting with AI-drafted copy are also the ones without robust fact-checking capacity.

A student should weigh the industry's finances first and our score second. We'd rather say that than claim more for our own factor than it deserves.

The number that should decide this

One comparison matters more than any other in this profile.

Roughly 95,000 students are enrolled in journalism and mass communication programmes in the United States, according to the University of Georgia's annual enrolment survey — a figure that has ticked slightly upward.

The total working population of reporters, correspondents and broadcast news analysts is around 45,000–50,000.

That is roughly two students in the pipeline for every working journalist in the country.

This is not a statement about talent or effort. It's arithmetic. And it explains something the AI conversation cannot: why journalism graduates struggle even in years when the industry isn't cutting.

The practical consequence: journalism is a field where the *degree* is abundant and the *evidence of doing it* is scarce. Which shapes all of the advice below.

Why journalism scores the way it does — the six factors

Here's how desk and aggregation work answers them.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

Nearly all of it.

Rewriting wire copy. Aggregating other outlets' coverage. Summarising reports and filings. Routine sports and earnings write-ups. Headline and SEO optimisation. Transcription and first-pass editing.

What resists: being in the room, cultivating a source who trusts you, obtaining a document nobody published, standing behind a claim legally, and knowing when someone is lying to you.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

The worst of any career in this index, and it was broken before AI arrived.

Section 5 covers why. The short version: the traditional apprenticeship — local paper, desk shifts, learning the craft on small stories — thinned dramatically for economic reasons, and what remained of it is now automating.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

For real reporting, more than people assume. Being physically present at a council meeting, a court, a scene, or a source's kitchen table is not replicable. For desk work, none of it.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At the investigative end substantially; at the desk end not at all.

A source risking their job talks to a person, not an outlet. And someone must be legally answerable for what is published.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

No. Journalism has no licence and — for good reasons of press freedom — should not.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

At the investigative end constantly; at the desk end rarely.

The entry path — broken early, and for different reasons

This is where journalism differs most instructively from every other career in this index.

Everywhere else, entry-path erosion is a recent story. AI absorbs the junior tasks, the on-ramp narrows over three or four years, and the profession is left healthy at the top and thin at the bottom.

Journalism's on-ramp had already thinned two decades ago. Local titles closed. Regional newsrooms consolidated. The entry-level reporting jobs disappeared with the revenue that funded them.

So when we rate journalism 8.5 on this factor, most of that rating is not about automation at all. It's about an industry that spent twenty years removing the rungs for economic reasons, and has now automated what was left of them.

Why this matters for how a family reads the score. In nursing, an entry-path rating of 2.0 tells you something durable — clinical hours are mandated by law and won't disappear. In journalism, the 8.5 reflects several forces, only one of which our framework measures, and the non-AI part is both larger and less likely to reverse.

The general lesson: when a factor rates badly, ask what's actually driving it. Automation-driven erosion might reverse if firms rediscover the value of training juniors. Economics-driven erosion does not reverse unless the money comes back.

What the trend shows

Desk journalism: 7.0 → 7.8 → 8.3. Up 1.3.

Investigative reporting: 4.5 → 4.8 → 5.1. Up 0.6.

The gap widened from 2.5 points to 3.2. The pattern is the same as everywhere in this index — original work holds, processing work doesn't. What is different is that journalism started the period with the highest desk score we measured, and the cuts have continued regardless.

Press Gazette's tracker logged at least **3,434 journalism job cuts across the US and UK in 2025**, with 2026 running at a pace that may exceed it — including at the Washington Post, Politico, Vox Media, Axios, CNBC, CBS News and the Wall Street Journal by early spring.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Judgment under novelty	Strong in investigation	Durable	Original reporting on unprecedented events resists automation entirely.
Human trust / accountability	Strong at the reporting end	Durable	Sources trust people, not outlets. Legal liability attaches to a named human.
Physical / embodied	Real for original reporting	Durable	Being in the room cannot be simulated.
Regulatory / licensing	None	n/a	And shouldn't exist — press freedom depends on it.

The honest read. Journalism's protections are genuine and they are all attached to original reporting. The problem is not that the protected work is unprotected. It's that there is far less of it being paid for than there used to be.

Where the work actually went

This is the constructive half, and it's more substantial than the headlines suggest.

Digital-native and subscription outlets have added an estimated 15,000-plus positions since 2020. The economics that work now are subscription and membership rather than display advertising — which changes who is hiring and what they want.

Newsletter and independent journalism is now a serious segment: over 35,000 active journalist-run publications on platforms like Substack and Beehiiv, and legacy outlets including the Financial Times launching on those platforms to reach new audiences.

Nonprofit newsrooms — ProPublica, The Marshall Project, Inside Climate News, and a growing set of state and local nonprofits — have continued hiring through the cutting cycle. The roles are competitive, pay below private-sector peers, and cannot come close to absorbing the number of journalists being laid off. They are real jobs and they are not a solution.

Trade and specialist publications are smaller but viable, and consistently short of people who genuinely understand a technical field.

Public media has been relatively stable at around 15,000 full-time positions, though funding debates introduce real uncertainty.

And the largest destination of all is adjacent rather than inside. The PR-to-journalist ratio has widened to roughly **six to one**. Communications, content and brand journalism absorb far more journalism graduates than newsrooms do — which is worth knowing before choosing the degree rather than after.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Getting people to tell you things** — source cultivation, and the single least automatable

skill in this profession.

2. **Being physically present** — at the meeting, the court, the scene. 3. **Verification** — knowing what's true, which is a scarcer skill as unverified content

volume rises.

4. **Legal and ethical judgment** — knowing what can be published, and standing behind it. 5. **Knowing when someone is lying to you** — the thing no system does.

Notably absent: writing speed, volume of output, and headline optimisation. These were the traditional markers of a strong junior and are entirely automated.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The work itself, when you get to do it, is among the most meaningful available. Holding power to account, finding out what actually happened, telling someone's story properly — people who do this describe it in terms closer to vocation than employment, and the ones who leave almost always miss it.

The skills travel exceptionally well. Verification, interviewing, working a beat, writing clearly under pressure, and explaining complexity are genuinely valuable and increasingly scarce — in policy, research, communications, investigation, law and consultancy.

Independent publishing is a genuine route in a way it wasn't a decade ago. Some of the best-known journalists in the country now run their own publications with six-figure subscriber bases. It is difficult and it is real.

And specialisation is rewarded. Freelance income has become harder for general-interest writing and *easier* for vertical specialists — one of the clearest signals in this profile about where to point.

What's genuinely hard about it

Pay is low relative to the education required, and it has been for a long time.

Precarity is structural. Average tenure at a single outlet has fallen to around 3.2 years, from 5.1 in 2012, and roughly 12% of working journalists hold a second job.

There is no ladder. One industry analyst put it starkly: there is no ladder left to climb, only avoiding falling off. That's a harsh framing and it isn't inaccurate for the general-interest end.

Building a freelance practice takes time. Industry estimates put it at 12–18 months to replace a staff salary, which is a real financial requirement most graduates don't have.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Journalism tends to suit people who:

- **Get people to talk to them.** The core skill, largely untrainable, and instantly recognisable in people who have it.
- **Are genuinely curious about other people's lives** rather than about writing
- **Are comfortable being unwelcome** — much of real reporting is asking people things they'd rather not answer
- **Are stubborn** — most stories are refusals until they aren't
- **Can accept insecurity** as a permanent condition rather than an early-career phase

It's harder for people who:

- Want to **write** more than they want to **find things out**. This is the most common mistake, and it's the difference between journalism and content work.
- Need **financial stability** early
- Find **rejection and conflict** draining
- Are drawn to the **idea** of journalism from film and television rather than the daily reality

What else is moving this market

Everything in section 3, plus one thing worth adding: **search referral traffic has collapsed for many publishers** as AI-generated answers replace clicks. That is a direct technology-driven revenue hit on top of the older advertising collapse, and it is currently getting worse rather than better.

The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

Journalism is the profession where AI creates the most demand for the thing it can't do.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE JOURNALIST LOOKS LIKE

- 1. Verify at scale.** As unverified content volume rises, the ability to establish what is actually true becomes more valuable, not less. This is journalism's central skill and it is appreciating.
- 2. Use the tools for the grunt work.** Transcription, document search, data extraction, first-pass research. Investigative work involves enormous volumes of material, and these tools genuinely help.
- 3. Investigate AI itself.** Algorithmic accountability, AI in public services, automated decision-making — a beat that barely existed five years ago and is badly under-covered.
- 4. Understand the failure modes.** Newsrooms are publishing AI-assisted copy, often without adequate checking. Someone who knows where these systems fabricate is immediately useful.
- 5. Build a direct audience.** The economics that work now are subscription and membership. A journalist with their own readership has something no employer can take away.

CONCRETE PREPARATION

Before the degree: start publishing now. A newsletter, a local beat, a specialist blog. In a field with two students per working journalist, the degree is not the differentiator — evidence of doing the work is.

During: get real bylines from year one. Student media, local outlets, freelance. Learn verification and public records properly — they are the durable skills. And **choose a beat:** health, climate, courts, local government, technology. Specialists are hiring; generalists are not.

And be honest about where you're aiming. Investigative and specialist reporting are the protected ends. Desk work at a general-interest outlet is the exposed one and it is shrinking.

The routes in

ROUTE	ASSESSMENT
Journalism degree + relentless bylines	Works if the bylines are real. The degree alone does not.
Subject degree + journalism training	Often stronger. Specialists are in demand; general reporters are not.
Trade and specialist publications	Smaller, viable, chronically short of people who understand the field.
Nonprofit newsrooms	Genuinely hiring, competitive, pay below peers, cannot absorb the displaced.
Independent / newsletter publishing	Real, difficult, and increasingly legitimate. Takes 12–18 months to replace a salary.
Communications and content	Where most journalism graduates actually end up. Worth knowing beforehand.

Where a journalism degree can take them later

The skills genuinely transfer, and this is the honest strength of the qualification even where the career doesn't work out: communications and public affairs, policy research, investigation and compliance, documentary and audio production, publishing, law (verification and argument transfer well), and independent publishing.

Two notes. Communications and PR absorb the largest share, and the ratio is roughly six PR professionals to every journalist. And content-production roles built on volume score like marketing execution at 8.2, not like journalism. They look adjacent and they aren't.

What to look for in a journalism program

1. Original reporting or content production? The single most important distinction. A programme built around producing content is training for the automated tier.

2. Do students get real bylines, in real outlets, from year one?

3. Are verification, public records and media law taught properly? These are the durable skills. Programmes vary enormously.

4. **Specialist beats.** Does the programme support developing genuine expertise in a field, or produce generalists?

5. **Where are graduates actually working — by name?** Not "in media." Which outlets, and doing what?

Questions to ask a journalism program

On outcomes — ask hard here:

- Where are last year's graduates working, by name of outlet and job title?
- What proportion are in journalism roles rather than communications or content?
- How has that changed in five years?

On practice:

- Do students publish in real outlets, and from which year?
- How is verification taught? Public records? Media law?
- Can students develop a specialist beat?

On honesty:

- Given the industry contraction, what do you tell prospective students about their prospects?

Red flags: outcomes described as "working in media"; no real publishing before final year; verification and media law as optional; a curriculum built around content production; reluctance to discuss the industry's contraction directly.

Go deeper — further reading

- **[Journalism job cuts in 2026: the running tracker](#)** — Press Gazette. An updated, sourced log of every announced cut. Uncomfortable reading and the most current picture

available. Worth an hour before committing three years.

- **Employment opportunities in journalism: where the jobs are right now** — Mediabistro. The source of the 91,000-to-55,000 publishing employment figure, and a clear-eyed account of which sectors are actually hiring. Read it for the migration story rather than the gloom.
- **Journalism jobs 2026: where to find work and get hired** — on newsletters, nonprofits and brand journalism absorbing roles under different titles. The most useful practical guide to where the work moved.

The counterargument — read this one:

There is a real case that our score is measuring the wrong thing entirely, and it cuts both ways.

The optimistic version: journalism as a *practice* is not declining at all. Digital-native outlets added 15,000-plus roles since 2020. Newsletter journalism is a \$2 billion segment with 35,000-plus active publications. Freelancers now account for 30–35% of bylined content in major US publications. On this reading, the work migrated and our score is measuring the decline of one business model rather than of a profession.

The pessimistic version: our 8.3 is too low, because it only measures automation. If we scored industry health, desk journalism would be near the top of this index and would have been for a decade.

Where we land: we think the optimistic version is partly right about the work and wrong about the arithmetic. Fifteen thousand new digital roles against a loss of 60,000-plus is a migration, not a replacement — and 95,000 students are entering the funnel behind it. So we hold the score, and we say plainly that a family should weigh the industry's economics more heavily than our number. This is the one profile where our framework is least sufficient, and pretending otherwise would be the most misleading thing we could do.

Bottom line

As preparation for a newsroom desk job, a journalism degree is a poor bet — and honest programmes will say so.

The industry has contracted by roughly 60% since 2008 for reasons that have nothing to do with AI. Around 2,900 newspapers have closed. Two students are enrolled for every working

journalist. **And AI is now removing the desk work that was the last remaining cushion.**

As a skill set, it holds up much better than the headline suggests. Verification, sourcing, interviewing, working a beat and writing clearly under pressure are genuinely valuable and increasingly scarce — and they travel into policy, research, investigation, communications and law.

And the protected end of journalism is real. Investigative work at 5.1 and specialist reporting at 5.8 are protected by the things that always protected them: being in the room, being trusted by sources, and being answerable for what you publish. There is simply less of it being paid for.

So the useful advice is narrow rather than negative. Publish now, before the degree. Get real bylines from year one. Choose a beat and become genuinely expert in something. Point at investigative, specialist or trade work rather than general news. Understand that communications absorbs most graduates, and decide whether that's acceptable before enrolling rather than after.

And one honest thing worth saying. Journalism is one of very few careers where the work itself — finding out what actually happened and telling people — is straightforwardly worth doing. **That's why people keep entering a contracting industry, and it isn't irrational.** But it should be chosen with the numbers in front of you, not despite them.

Discussion questions

Part 1 — About the work itself

1. **Do they want to write, or do they want to find things out?** This is the most important

question in this profile and the answers lead to completely different careers.

2. What made journalism appealing? A specific story, a person, a moment? 3. Are they comfortable being unwelcome? Much of real reporting is asking people things they'd

rather not answer.

4. Have they ever got someone to tell them something they didn't want to? That's the core skill.

Part 2 — Reacting to the findings

5. The industry has contracted roughly 60% since 2008, mostly before AI. Did they know that? 6. Roughly 95,000 students are enrolled against 45,000–50,000 working journalists. What do they

make of that?

7. Investigative reporting scores 5.1 and desk work 8.3. Does that change where they'd aim?

Part 2b — The harder conversation

8. Have you both looked at the Press Gazette cuts tracker together? It's uncomfortable and

it's current.

9. Communications and PR absorb far more journalism graduates than newsrooms do. Is that an

acceptable outcome for them, honestly?

10. Building a freelance practice takes 12–18 months to replace a salary. What's the financial

plan if that's the route?

11. Average tenure at one outlet is 3.2 years. How do they feel about that as a permanent

condition?

Part 2c — The other side

12. Of what's genuinely good — the work mattering, portable skills, independent publishing,

specialisation — which matters most?

13. Looking at "who this work suits": which items sound like them? Answer separately, then

compare.

14. Are they stubborn? Most stories are refusals until they aren't.

Part 2d — The AI question, practically

15. As unverified content volume rises, verification becomes more valuable. Does that reframe

anything for them?

16. Algorithmic accountability is a badly under-covered beat. Is that interesting?

Part 3 — Testing it against reality

17. **The most valuable single action, and it's available today:** start publishing. A

newsletter, a local beat, a specialist blog. Nothing else demonstrates whether they'll actually do this.

18. Find a journalist two to five years in — not a well-known one — and ask what their week

looks like and what they earn.

Part 4 — About the program

19. Ask each programme the outcome questions from section 13. Push past "working in media."

20. Do students publish in real outlets, and from which year? 21. Is verification, public records and media law taught properly?

Part 5 — Widening the frame

22. Have they considered a **subject degree plus journalism training** instead? Specialists are

in demand; generalists aren't.

23. Would they be happy in communications, policy research or investigation if journalism

doesn't work out? Those are the realistic adjacent destinations.

24. If journalism weren't available, what would they choose? The answer usually reveals what they're actually drawn to.

Part 6 — For the parent, alone

25. **Am I about to try to talk them out of this?** If so — is that based on the numbers, or on worry?

26. Can I help them find the version of this that still exists, rather than only the reasons not to?

27. Am I prepared to support a career with genuine financial precarity, and have I said so clearly either way?

28. What's the one thing I most want them to understand — in a sentence, without a number in it?

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For journalism specifically, we've flagged that our framework measures automation exposure and cannot see industry economics — and that for this profession the economics matter considerably more.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.